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Montour, Panhandle trails celebrate historic connection

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By David Guo, Pittsburgh Post-Gazette

Fans of the Montour Trail, with its ultimate link to Washington, D.C., and the Panhandle Trail, with its sights set on Cincinnati, had a celebratory day yesterday.

The all-afternoon event called Function at the Junction was appropriate, given the occasion.

First, the function: A double ribbon-cutting ceremony at noon with public officials, trail leaders and other VIPs representing towns in Allegheny and Washington counties such as Collier, both Robinsons -- Allegheny and Washington counties -- McDonald and Mount Pleasant, the hub of the day's activities.

After the speeches and thank-yous, the clog dancers and the rock band Steeltown took over. There also were bike rides, trail walks, a petting zoo, face painters and a half-dozen food booths.

Now, the junction: The final, 0.7-mile segment of the Montour-Panhandle trail connection is in Mount Pleasant, on Noblestown Road, a mile west of McDonald.

Also unveiled less than a quarter-mile away was a six-mile Primrose-to-Joffre stretch of the Panhandle Trail, which now allows use of 26 miles of the eventual 29-mile trail from Collier nearly to Weirton, W.Va., and some 40 miles of the 47-mile Montour Trail from Moon to Clairton.

It's been a long time coming for Stan Sattinger, of Bethel Park, founding president and co-founder of the Montour Trail Council. Mr. Sattinger, who was chairman of Saturday's event, said the McDonald area had been a focal point pretty much since the council was founded in 1989.

The nearly 1,000-foot-long McDonald Trestle at mile 17.5 was one of the largest engineering projects the council has undertaken. When finished in 2003, the next steps were easy to see from points north and south.

"My own philosophy is the opening of the trestle completed the centerpiece," Mr. Sattinger said. "We all had been looking at the trestle for years and years. It's been a focal point of the trail."

With the nearby junction opening as well, Mr. Sattinger sees possibilities heading east and west, too.

"This new path has connections for bike tourists that generally can follow the four main compass points. You come to McDonald and you now have a choice," he said.

"At mile 18, you can now say, hmm, do I want to go east to Carnegie today, or do I want to go west to Weirton?"

"Where else in the country do you have a crossing of two major trails? I can tell you, it's pretty rare," Mr. Sattinger said.

Montour Trail enthusiasts like to think beyond the given, and they know that beyond Clairton lie links to the Great Allegheny Passage to Cumberland, Md., and the Chesapeake and Ohio Canal towpath to Washington, D.C.

What's not as well known, said Ned Williams, president of the Panhandle Trail Association, is that, beyond Weirton, there's talk of a link across the Ohio River to Steubenville and from there, due west to Cincinnati.

For skeptics, Mr. Williams, of Robinson, Washington County, offers this: Who would've bet a decade ago on a multi-state, 300-mile-plus trail network from Pittsburgh to Washington?

"The real big picture is, you have a rapidly developing trail in Pennsylvania all the way to Washington," he said, "and also west into Ohio, where there are canals and rails all over the place."

"The connection between them, Pennsylvania and Ohio, the best connection between them, is the Panhandle Trail. That's the importance of these two trails," he said.

In the world of networking recreational trails, he said, "This is like a junction between interstates."

What's interesting to Mr. Williams is how the Montour and Panhandle have different histories, informed by the differences in landscape.

Whereas the Montour Trail was built on a freight line that connected coal mines, Mr. Williams said, the Panhandle Trail tracks the old Panhandle Division of the Pennsylvania Railroad rail and passenger lines. It passes more populated towns such as Carnegie, Oakdale, Burgettstown and Weirton.

The Panhandle Trail passes some 40 feet beneath the Montour Trail's McDonald Trestle at Mile 17.5 between McDonald and Primrose, but the trails do not physically intersect there. That's what necessitated the grade-leveling junction connector a half mile north.

"You can see it but you can't get there," Mr. Sattinger said. "You have to use the connector."

Just as 2003 was a big year on the Montour side because of the completion of the McDonald Trestle, it also marked a milestone on the Panhandle. That's when Washington County laid plans to develop the 17 miles that it owns through McDonald, Fort Cherry, Cecil and Hendersonville.

String it all together, Mr. Sattinger and Mr. Williams agreed, and there are a lot of towns, volunteers and businesses that own a piece of this weekend's action.

Not to mention Shorty Long, who wrote the 1966 Motown hit after which the event got its name.

"It's a big connection celebration. The main purpose is, we want to thank the municipal officials and Washington County and all the local volunteers," Mr. Williams said.

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